

Forests and Mountains



STRETCHING ACROSS the center of Africa is the second largest area of rainforest in the world. It grows in the tropical regions around the Equator, where the climate is hot and wet all year round. A variety of birds, such as hornbills, turacos, and pittas, thrive in this rich environment, where there are plenty of leaves, fruits, and insects to eat and trees and bushes to nest in. There are also areas of rainforest growing on the lower slopes of the mountains in East Africa. On the higher slopes is a cold, misty world of grasses and giant plants, which is home to birds such as eagles and sunbirds.

The island of Madagascar off the east coast of Africa has areas of both mountain and rainforest, as well as deserts and grasslands. Many unique animals have evolved in this varied environment. These include several families of birds that are not found anywhere else in the world.

Green wood hoopoe

These birds move around in a noisy family group, probing tree trunks and branches for insect grubs with their long, curved bills. Several times each hour, the birds perform a cackling display, which helps keep the main group together. Up to ten green wood hoopoes help each set of parents gather food and defend the eggs and chicks. When the chicks grow up, they may become "helpers" for the adults who cared for them.

During the cackling display, the birds face each other, rocking to and fro and bowing low.

Green wood hoopoe
(*Phoeniculus purpureus*)
Length: 1 ft 4 in (40 cm)

Tail is raised high in the air when the bird displays.

Red-tufted sunbird
(*Nectarinia johnstoni*)
Length: 11 in (27 cm)
Male's tail: up to 8 in (20 cm)

Both males and females puff out these red tufts to attract a mate.

Male's chest feathers turn green during the breeding season; at other times, they are brown.

Red-tufted sunbird

This large mountain sunbird often perches on flowers to probe for nectar with its long, thin, curved bill. It has strong feet and sharp claws for gripping slippery leaves. It also eats a lot of insects, holding them in the jagged edges near the tip of its bill. As it feeds, it helps spread pollen from flower to flower. It has little flaps over its nostrils to stop pollen dust from getting up its nose.

Strong, hooked bill is used mainly for catching insects but the helmet vanga will also eat frogs and small reptiles, such as this chameleon.

Helmet vanga
(*Euryceros prevostii*)
Length: 1 ft (31 cm)

Helmet vanga

This bird belongs to a group of birds called the vangas, found only on the island of Madagascar. There are 14 species of vanga on the island. These probably evolved over millions of years from a single ancestor, which crossed over from the African mainland. Each of the species lives in a different habitat, so that there are enough nest sites and food to go round.